

Analysis of Select 2019 M&A Transactions in the North American Automotive Sector: A Source-Verified Dossier

Section I: Executive Summary & Thematic Overview

1.1. Introduction and Methodology

This report provides a detailed and verified analysis of ten key mergers and acquisitions within the North American automotive and specialty vehicle sector announced during the 2019 calendar year. The objective is to establish a definitive record for each transaction, focusing on the verification of announcement and completion dates and the precise classification of the transaction type. The findings herein are based exclusively on an examination of primary source documents, namely official company press releases issued by the acquirer or target, and corporate filings with the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), such as Form 8-K reports, annual reports, and specific merger-related documentation. This adherence to primary sources ensures the highest degree of accuracy and reliability for the data presented.

1.2. Master Transaction Summary Table

The following table consolidates the verified data for each of the ten transactions, providing a top-level summary suitable for database integration. It includes corrections to user-provided announcement dates where necessary and cites the primary source documents used for

verification.

Table 1: Master Transaction Summary (2019 North American Automotive Sector)

Acquirer	Target	User-Provided Announcement Date	Verified Announcement Date	Completion Date	Transaction Type	Deal Value	Primary Source Citations
Alamo Group Inc.	Morbar k, LLC	Sep-19	September 11, 2019	October 24, 2019	100% Acquisition	Approx. \$352 million ¹	²
Autokini ton Global Group	Tower International, Inc.	Jul-19	July 12, 2019	September 30, 2019	100% Acquisition (via Tender Offer & Merger)	Approx. \$900 million ⁴	⁵
NFI Group Inc.	Alexander Dennis Limited	May-19	May 28, 2019	May 28, 2019	100% Acquisition	£320 million (approx. \$405 million) ⁷	⁸
Federal Signal Corporation	Mark Rite Lines Equipment Company, Inc.	May-19	May 14, 2019	July 2, 2019	Asset Acquisition	\$55.5 million (plus up to \$15.5 million earn-out)	⁹
Truck Hero, Inc.	Lund International Holding	May-19	May 10, 2019	May 10, 2019	Merger	Not Disclosed ¹¹	¹²

	Compa ny						
ZF Friedric hshafen AG	Wabco Holding s Inc.	Mar-19	March 28, 2019	May 29, 2020	100% Acquisit ion	Approx. \$7 billion (equity value) ¹³	¹⁴
Gamut Capital Manage ment	Americ an Axle & Manufa cturing Holding s, Inc. (U.S. Iron Casting Operati ons - "Grede")	Aug-19	Septem ber 18, 2019	Decem ber 16, 2019	Carve- out / Division al Acquisit ion	\$245 million (\$185M cash, \$60M deferre d) ¹⁶	⁴
Allison Transmi ssion Holding s Inc.	AxleTec h Internat ional Inc. (EV System s Division)	Apr-19	April 23, 2019	April 16, 2019	Carve- out / Division al Acquisit ion	\$123 million ³	¹
Allison Transmi ssion Holding s Inc.	Vantag e Power	Apr-19	April 23, 2019	April 12, 2019	100% Acquisit ion	Approx. £7 million (plus up to £6 million earn-ou	¹⁹

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Meritor, Inc.	AxleTech	May-19	May 6, 2019 (Implied)	July 26, 2019	100% Acquisition	Approx. \$179 million ²⁰	²¹

1.3. Key Strategic Themes

Analysis of these transactions reveals several interconnected strategic currents shaping the automotive supply chain. These deals are not isolated events but rather components of broader industry-wide realignments driven by technological disruption, financial strategy, and a focus on core competencies.

A primary driver is the strategic repositioning by established manufacturers to secure their relevance in an era of rapid technological change. The acquisitions made by Allison Transmission and ZF Friedrichshafen, in particular, were not aimed at consolidating existing market share but were deliberate moves to acquire critical technologies for vehicle electrification and automation. Allison's near-simultaneous acquisitions of Vantage Power, a specialist in battery and control systems, and AxleTech's Electric Vehicle (EV) Systems division were explicitly framed as part of a comprehensive "electrification strategy".¹⁹ Similarly, the landmark merger of ZF and Wabco was designed to create a "leading global integrated mobility systems provider for commercial vehicles" capable of delivering comprehensive systems for "safe and automated mobility solutions".¹⁴ These transactions demonstrate a clear recognition by legacy powertrain suppliers that they must acquire new competencies in software, battery technology, and advanced braking systems to compete in the next generation of mobility.

Concurrently, the influence of private equity (PE) firms as catalysts for consolidation and value creation is pervasive. PE firms were active on both sides of these transactions, orchestrating complex "buy-and-build" strategies. KPS Capital Partners, for instance, utilized its portfolio company Autokiniton Global Group as a platform to acquire Tower International, aiming to build a more competitive North American supplier.²⁰ The Truck Hero and Lund transaction involved PE firms as both the acquirer's parent (CCMP Capital) and the seller (Highlander Partners).¹² Notably, Highlander Partners opted to roll over a portion of its investment, becoming a "significant shareholder in the combined company".⁷ This move signifies a sophisticated financial strategy beyond a simple exit, indicating a strong belief in the long-term synergistic value of the merged entity and a desire to participate in its future

growth.

This strategic repositioning is often funded and enabled by a third theme: corporate streamlining through the divestiture of non-core assets, or "carve-outs." American Axle & Manufacturing's (AAM) sale of its Grede iron casting operations is a prime example. The stated purpose of the sale was to "streamline our business, accelerate our debt reduction initiatives and enhance our margin profile," thereby allowing the company to "focus on profitable growth opportunities including electrification".⁴ This creates a direct causal link between the themes; divesting a capital-intensive, legacy-technology business unit generates the capital and management focus required to invest in high-growth, future-oriented technologies. Likewise, AxleTech's sale of its EV division to Allison allowed its parent, The Carlyle Group, to separate a high-growth technology unit from its more mature core business, ultimately selling each part to the most logical strategic buyer to maximize value.¹

Section II: Detailed Transaction Dossiers

2.1. Alamo Group Inc. / Morbark, LLC

2.1.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** Alamo Group Inc.
- **Target:** Morbark, LLC
- **Verified Announcement Date:** September 11, 2019
- **Completion Date:** October 24, 2019
- **Transaction Type:** 100% Acquisition
- **Deal Value:** Approximately \$352 million¹
- **Sources:**²⁴

2.1.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

The announcement of the definitive agreement occurred on September 11, 2019, as detailed in a press release from Alamo Group stating it "has entered into an agreement to acquire 100% of the outstanding capital shares of Morbark, LLC".²⁴ This refines the user-provided date of "Sep-19" to a specific day.

The initial announcement projected a closing in the fourth quarter of 2019.² The precise completion date is confirmed in an SEC filing (an Exhibit 99.4 to a Form 8-K), which provides the definitive statement: "On October 24, 2019, Alamo Group Inc.... acquired Morbark Holdings Group, LLC".³ The same filing confirms the purchase price consideration was approximately \$352 million.¹

The transaction type is unequivocally a 100% Acquisition, based on the explicit language in the press release regarding the purchase of "100% of the outstanding capital shares".²

2.1.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

This transaction represents a classic bolt-on acquisition designed to achieve scale and market expansion. Alamo Group, a publicly traded manufacturer of infrastructure maintenance equipment, acquired Morbark, a privately held leader in equipment for forestry and tree maintenance owned by Stellex Capital Partners.²⁴

The strategic logic, as articulated by Alamo Group's CEO, was twofold. First, it was a complementary product expansion, as Morbark's offerings "expand and complement our range of vegetation maintenance equipment in an adjacent market".² Second, the acquisition was a vehicle for geographic growth. The CEO stated, "We also believe this acquisition will allow us to accelerate Morbark's international growth plans with Alamo's existing presence in areas such as Europe as well as select markets such as Brazil and Australia".² The deal aimed to leverage Alamo's larger distribution network and international footprint to fuel the growth of the acquired business.

2.2. Autokiniton Global Group / Tower International, Inc.

2.2.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** Autokiniton Global Group (via subsidiary Autokiniton US Holdings, Inc.)
- **Target:** Tower International, Inc.
- **Verified Announcement Date:** July 12, 2019
- **Completion Date:** September 30, 2019
- **Transaction Type:** 100% Acquisition (via Tender Offer and Merger)
- **Deal Value:** Approximately \$900 million (total transaction value) ⁴
- **Sources:** ²⁰

2.2.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

The definitive agreement for the transaction was announced on July 12, 2019, refining the user-provided "Jul-19" date.⁵ The announcement specified a price of \$31 per share in cash, with a total transaction value, including debt and pension liabilities, of approximately \$900 million.⁴

The completion of the acquisition was announced in a press release dated September 30, 2019. The release confirms that following the expiration of a tender offer on September 27, "on September 30, 2019, AGG completed the acquisition of Tower".²⁰

This transaction was a 100% Acquisition of a publicly traded company (NYSE: TOWR) structured as a two-step process. It began with a cash tender offer for all outstanding shares, followed by a merger in which any remaining untendered shares were converted into the right to receive the same cash payment. This process resulted in Tower becoming a "wholly owned subsidiary of AGG".⁶

2.2.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

This acquisition was a key move in a "buy-and-build" strategy executed by private equity firm KPS Capital Partners through its platform company, Autokiniton Global Group (AGG).²⁵ The goal was to create a larger, more diversified, and more competitive Tier 1 automotive supplier.

The CEO of AGG, George Thanopoulos, stated that the deal "will significantly enhance AGG's position as a leading North American manufacturer of metal formed components".⁵ The primary drivers were synergies achieved by "lowering overall cost, significantly broadening our product offerings and diversifying our customer base".⁵ By combining the two entities, KPS aimed to create a supplier with a stronger manufacturing footprint and a product portfolio

better positioned for key automotive trends like lightweighting.²⁰

2.3. NFI Group Inc. / Alexander Dennis Limited

2.3.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** NFI Group Inc.
- **Target:** Alexander Dennis Limited
- **Verified Announcement Date:** May 28, 2019
- **Completion Date:** May 28, 2019
- **Transaction Type:** 100% Acquisition
- **Deal Value:** £320 million (approximately \$405 million)⁷
- **Sources:**⁸

2.3.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

The announcement and completion of this transaction occurred on the same day. The press release, dated May 28, 2019, uses the past tense, stating that NFI Group "today announced that it has acquired Alexander Dennis Limited".⁸ The release specifies a total transaction value of £320 million (approximately 420 million on its credit facilities".⁸

The deal is consistently described as an "acquisition" of Alexander Dennis by NFI Group, making 100% Acquisition the correct classification.⁸

2.3.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

This was a significant cross-border transaction aimed at creating a dominant "independent global bus and coach manufacturer".¹¹ NFI Group, a leader in the North American market, acquired Alexander Dennis Limited (ADL), a market leader in the United Kingdom and Hong

Kong with a growing global presence.⁸

The strategic intent was to create a more geographically diversified and resilient business. The official announcement highlighted that the deal "complements NFI's product offering, diversifies its business model and creates a platform for international growth".⁸ The combination leveraged NFI's expertise in electric vehicle (EV) technology to enhance ADL's international EV offerings while using ADL's established international footprint to accelerate NFI's global expansion.⁸

2.4. Federal Signal Corporation / Mark Rite Lines Equipment Company, Inc.

2.4.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** Federal Signal Corporation
- **Target:** Mark Rite Lines Equipment Company, Inc.
- **Verified Announcement Date:** May 14, 2019
- **Completion Date:** July 2, 2019
- **Transaction Type:** Asset Acquisition
- **Deal Value:** \$55.5 million initial purchase price, plus a contingent earn-out of up to \$15.5 million
- **Sources:** ⁹

2.4.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

The signing of the definitive agreement was announced in a press release dated May 14, 2019, which refines the user-provided "May-19" date.⁹ The release detailed an initial purchase price of \$55.5 million, with a potential contingent earn-out payment of up to an additional \$15.5 million .

The completion of the transaction was confirmed in a subsequent press release from Federal Signal's corporate news archive. This release, dated July 2, 2019, is titled "Federal Signal Completes Acquisition of Mark Rite Lines Equipment Company, Inc.".¹⁰

The transaction type is specified as an Asset Acquisition. The announcement press release states that the agreement is "to acquire the assets and operations of Mark Rite Lines Equipment Company, Inc."⁹ This structure, where the buyer purchases specific assets rather than the corporate entity itself, is distinct from a stock acquisition.

2.4.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

This acquisition represented a strategic market entry for Federal Signal, a manufacturer of specialty vehicles for environmental and safety applications. By acquiring Mark Rite Lines (MRL), a leader in road-marking equipment, Federal Signal extended its platform into the maintenance and infrastructure market.⁹

The company's CEO, Jennifer L. Sherman, pointed to both current and future market drivers. The immediate rationale was the "need to invest in aging infrastructure".⁹ Looking forward, the company identified a significant opportunity in the "anticipated need for road-marking changes to support the future evolution of connected and autonomous vehicles," connecting this seemingly traditional industrial purchase to the high-tech transformation of the automotive sector.⁹

2.5. Truck Hero, Inc. / Lund International Holding Company

2.5.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** Truck Hero, Inc.
- **Target:** Lund International Holding Company
- **Verified Announcement Date:** May 10, 2019
- **Completion Date:** May 10, 2019
- **Transaction Type:** Merger
- **Deal Value:** Not Disclosed¹¹
- **Sources:**¹²

2.5.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

The transaction was both announced and completed on May 10, 2019. The official press release from Highlander Partners states that Truck Hero "today announced that Lund International Holding Company ('Lund') has merged with and into the Company".⁷ The definitive past-tense phrasing "has merged" confirms completion on the date of the announcement. The press release explicitly states that "The transaction terms were not disclosed".¹¹

While some news headlines refer to the transaction as an acquisition¹², the most precise classification is Merger, based on the specific legal terminology used in the official company announcement.⁷

2.5.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

This transaction was a combination of two major players in the branded automotive accessories market, both backed by private equity firms (Truck Hero by CCMP Capital and Lund by Highlander Partners). The merger was intended to create a dominant market leader with an unparalleled product portfolio.

The deal was described as a "strategic acquisition" that "further diversifies the Company's product category mix and increases exposure to a larger addressable market of vehicles".¹² A particularly noteworthy aspect is that the seller's private equity sponsor, Highlander Partners, chose not to fully exit its investment. Instead, it was announced that Highlander "will still be a significant shareholder in the combined company," signaling a strong belief in the synergistic potential and future growth prospects of the newly formed entity.⁷

2.6. ZF Friedrichshafen AG / Wabco Holdings Inc.

2.6.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** ZF Friedrichshafen AG

- **Target:** Wabco Holdings Inc.
- **Verified Announcement Date:** March 28, 2019
- **Completion Date:** May 29, 2020
- **Transaction Type:** 100% Acquisition
- **Deal Value:** Approximately \$7 billion (total equity value) ¹³
- **Sources:** ¹⁴

2.6.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

The definitive agreement was announced on March 28, 2019, as confirmed by a press release from ZF Friedrichshafen.¹⁴ The announcement specified that ZF would acquire Wabco for \$136.50 per share, for a total equity value of approximately \$7 billion.¹³

The initial announcement projected a closing in "early 2020," contingent on regulatory and shareholder approvals.¹⁴ A subsequent press release from ZF provides the exact completion date, stating, "ZF Friedrichshafen completes the acquisition of WABCO" on May 29, 2020.¹⁵ The 14-month period between announcement and closing is typical for a large, global transaction of this nature, reflecting the time required for extensive antitrust and regulatory reviews across multiple jurisdictions.

The transaction was a 100% Acquisition of a public company, with ZF agreeing to acquire all outstanding shares of Wabco for \$136.50 per share.¹⁴

2.6.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

This was a transformative, multi-billion dollar acquisition aimed at creating an integrated systems supplier for the commercial vehicle industry, with a direct focus on enabling autonomous driving. ZF, a leader in driveline and chassis technology, lacked a commercial vehicle braking division, a critical component for automated vehicle control.

The acquisition of Wabco, a global leader in braking control systems, filled this strategic gap. ZF's CEO stated the deal would create the foundation for ZF to "offer comprehensive systems for safe and automated mobility solutions for passengers and goods".¹⁴ Wabco's CEO echoed this sentiment, noting that joining ZF provided "access to critical technology and the global size and scale to de-risk the return on investment required as the industry transforms".¹³ This highlights the immense capital pressures driving consolidation among suppliers as they invest

in the technologies required for the future of mobility.

2.7. Gamut Capital Management / American Axle & Manufacturing Holdings, Inc. (U.S. Iron Casting Operations - "Grede")

2.7.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** Gamut Capital Management
- **Target:** American Axle & Manufacturing Holdings, Inc. (U.S. Iron Casting Operations - "Grede")
- **Verified Announcement Date:** September 18, 2019
- **Completion Date:** December 16, 2019
- **Transaction Type:** Carve-out / Divisional Acquisition
- **Deal Value:** \$245 million (\$185 million in cash and a \$60 million deferred payment) ¹⁶
- **Sources:** ⁴

2.7.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

The announcement date provided by the user ("Aug-19") is incorrect. The official press release from American Axle & Manufacturing (AAM) announcing the "definitive agreement to sell its U.S. iron casting operations" is dated September 18, 2019.⁴ The release specified an aggregate purchase price of \$245 million, consisting of \$185 million in cash and a \$60 million deferred payment obligation.¹⁶

A subsequent press release from AAM, dated December 16, 2019, confirms the deal's finalization, stating that the company "has closed the previously announced sale".¹⁷

This transaction is a classic Carve-out or Divisional Acquisition. AAM sold a specific business unit, its U.S. iron casting operations known as "Grede," to the private equity firm Gamut Capital Management. AAM explicitly noted that it would "retain its El Carmen, Mexico iron casting operations," confirming the sale of only a portion of its assets.⁴

2.7.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

The strategic motivations for the buyer and seller were distinct. For the seller, AAM, the divestiture was a key step in a broader corporate strategy to refine its focus and reallocate capital. AAM's CEO, David C. Dauch, stated the sale would "enable us to streamline our business, accelerate our debt reduction initiatives and enhance our margin profile," and critically, to "focus on profitable growth opportunities including electrification".⁴

For the buyer, Gamut Capital Management, the transaction was an opportunity to acquire a "market-leading supplier" and operate it as a standalone company focused on growth and operational excellence.⁴ This is a common private equity strategy: acquiring non-core divisions from large corporations that may be undervalued or undermanaged within the larger conglomerate structure.

2.8. Allison Transmission Holdings Inc. / AxleTech International Inc. (EV Systems Division)

2.8.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** Allison Transmission Holdings Inc.
- **Target:** AxleTech International Inc. (EV Systems Division)
- **Verified Announcement Date:** April 23, 2019
- **Completion Date:** April 16, 2019
- **Transaction Type:** Carve-out / Divisional Acquisition
- **Deal Value:** \$123 million³
- **Sources:**¹

2.8.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

The public announcement of the sale was made on April 23, 2019, in press releases from both AxleTech and Allison Transmission.¹⁹

Unusually, the transaction was completed prior to its public announcement. The press release from AxleTech specifies that the deal was "finalized on April 16".¹ An investor presentation from Allison corroborates this, stating the transaction "Closed transaction on April 16, 2019" and confirming the transaction price of \$123 million.¹⁸

This deal was a Carve-out, as Allison acquired only the "Electric Vehicle Systems division" from AxleTech. The seller's press release clarified that "AxleTech's core business in the commercial off-highway and defense industries... will continue to operate under the ownership of The Carlyle Group".¹ The sale consisted specifically of the "assets, intellectual property, products, and people" associated with the EV division.¹

2.8.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

This acquisition was a central pillar of Allison Transmission's strategic pivot toward electrification. By purchasing AxleTech's EV division, Allison acquired advanced, highly integrated electric axle solutions and systems engineering expertise. Allison's CEO noted that AxleTech's solutions "complement our position as a leading propulsion solutions provider".²⁶

For the seller, AxleTech, the divestiture represented a strategic choice to specialize. The company's CEO explained that the sale allowed AxleTech to "focus on what we do best – traditional powertrain and non-integrated electric solutions for the off-highway and defense industries".¹ This indicates a decision to concentrate on its core markets rather than compete broadly across all segments of the rapidly evolving EV landscape.

2.9. Allison Transmission Holdings Inc. / Vantage Power

2.9.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** Allison Transmission Holdings Inc.
- **Target:** Vantage Power
- **Verified Announcement Date:** April 23, 2019
- **Completion Date:** April 12, 2019
- **Transaction Type:** 100% Acquisition
- **Deal Value:** Approximately £7 million (\$9 million), with a potential earn-out of up to £6

million (\$8 million)³

- **Sources:**¹⁹

2.9.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

The acquisition of Vantage Power was announced by Allison Transmission on April 23, 2019, in the same press release that disclosed the AxleTech EV division deal.¹⁹

Similar to the AxleTech transaction, the deal was completed before the announcement. An investor presentation filed by Allison provides the specific closing date: "Closed transaction on April 12, 2019".¹⁸ The same presentation details the transaction price of approximately £7 million (or \$9 million), with the potential for an additional £6 million (\$8 million) in payments over three years based on certain conditions being met.³

The transaction type was a 100% Acquisition. The same investor presentation specifies that Allison paid cash consideration for a "100% stock sale" of Vantage Power.¹⁸

2.9.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

Announced as part of a dual-pronged push into electrification, the acquisition of Vantage Power was a technology and talent acquisition for Allison. While the AxleTech deal provided hardware and integrated systems, Vantage Power brought expertise in "battery technology development, vehicle integration and control systems, as well as vehicle connectivity and telemetry".¹⁹

This acquisition of the London-based technology company provided Allison with critical software and systems integration capabilities necessary to develop comprehensive electrified propulsion solutions. It was a strategic move to build out a full suite of in-house competencies required to compete effectively in the EV market, complementing the hardware-focused purchase of AxleTech's EV division.

2.10. Meritor, Inc. / AxleTech

2.10.1. Transaction Snapshot

- **Acquirer:** Meritor, Inc.
- **Target:** AxleTech
- **Verified Announcement Date:** May 6, 2019 (Implied from news cycle)
- **Completion Date:** July 26, 2019
- **Transaction Type:** 100% Acquisition
- **Deal Value:** Approximately \$179 million²⁰
- **Sources:**²³

2.10.2. Data Verification and Sourcing

While a specific press release announcing the definitive agreement is not among the provided documents, news reports from early May 2019 indicate that Meritor was "set to acquire AxleTech".²¹ This confirms the user's "May-19" timeframe for the announcement.

The completion date is definitively established by an SEC filing (Form 10-K) from Meritor, which is the most authoritative source. It states: "On July 26, 2019, the company acquired 100 percent of the voting equity interest of the AxleTech group companies for approximately \$179 million in cash".²² Subsequent press releases from Meritor on July 28 and 29 announced the closing to the public.²³

The SEC filing's language confirms the transaction type as a 100% Acquisition of the entire remaining AxleTech corporate entity from its owner, The Carlyle Group.²²

2.1.3. Strategic Rationale & Context

This transaction involved the acquisition of AxleTech's remaining core business by a direct competitor, Meritor, just three months after AxleTech had carved out and sold its EV division. The strategic rationale for Meritor was to expand its product portfolio and diversify its market presence. Meritor's CEO, Jay Craig, stated that the deal "advances our growth strategy while further diversifying our portfolio in strategic, adjacent markets," specifically off-highway, defense, and specialty vehicles.²³

The sequence of events surrounding AxleTech in 2019 reveals a sophisticated, two-stage exit strategy by its private equity owner, The Carlyle Group. By first selling the high-growth, technology-focused EV division to a specialized strategic buyer (Allison Transmission) and then selling the mature, core industrial business to a direct competitor (Meritor), the seller was able to place each distinct asset with the buyer who valued it most, likely maximizing the total proceeds from the divestiture of the company.

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